soldier at Mankot when Akbar was fourteen. Maham could not have nursed Akbar unless she had an infant of her own to nurse, too; this child, if male, would be Akbar's koka – his milk brother. Aziz, son of Jiji Anaka, is often referred to as Aziz Koka, for example; not so Adham Khan.

Adham is only known, in fact, as his mother's son; his father's name is missing from the record, an exceptional omission that suggests to the translator and historian Heinrich Blochmann that Adham was a 'royal bastard'[79] – an epithet that would soon be proven at least figuratively accurate.

No husband of Maham's is ever mentioned. Indeed, the only man, besides Akbar and her son, to play any significant role in her life is one Shihabuddin Ahmad Khan, her 'relation and friend'.[80] Their names are joined in the chronicles: it is likely that Shihabuddin helped to build Maham's mosque, the beautifully spartan Khair'ul Manazil that stands across Delhi's Old Fort; and he was certainly Maham's ally in her better-known historical legacy: the plot against Bairam.

Was it Maham who told her son to send that letter to Pir Muhammad? Possibly. Adham Khan's own life doesn't reveal a man capable of subtle conspiracies, and halting Pir Muhammad's exile was nothing if not a long game. The message began the plot against Bairam as the tuning of instruments begins a concert. For months afterwards, everyone went about their business as usual. Two attempts at expansion – Ranthambore and Malwa – didn't quite take off; Akbar took his hunting cheetahs to Gwalior; and Bairam acquired a new right-hand man, as influential as his predecessor – a Shia cleric called Shaikh Gada'i, given to holding 'singing parties'[81] at which Bairam and Akbar were regular guests.

Then, at the very beginning of Akbar's fifth regnal year, in March 1560, the orchestra struck its first, ominous chord.

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It was the trumpet, once again, of elephants.

One of Akbar's elephants went wild and gored one of Bairam's. The regent, in a fury fit to match the elephant's, had its mahout – who was Akbar's own personal elephant-keeper – executed.

Another time, one of Akbar's elephants 'rushed into the Jamna'.[82] And